

DriveAbility — FAQ

For Users

1. What is DriveAbility and who is it for? DriveAbility is a review platform for assistive driving technology; hand controls, amputee rings, pedal extensions, and similar devices. It's built for drivers with disabilities who want publicly sourced reviews from reviewers who share relevant lived experience. You can filter reviews by disability type to surface the perspectives most useful to you.
2. Do I need an account to read reviews? No, browsing reviews and product listings is open to everyone. You'll only need to create a free account if you want to submit your own review or build out a reviewer profile.
3. How are reviewers vetted? Can I trust the reviews? Each reviewer has a profile that surfaces their disability type and relevant context, so you can judge the source alongside the review itself. Reviews follow a documented methodology rather than being open-ended star ratings, which helps ensure consistency and usefulness across the platform. Additionally, suspicious or problematic users can be easily removed by admins.
4. I submitted a review but it isn't showing up, what happened? New reviews may go through a moderation step before appearing publicly. If yours hasn't appeared after 24 hours, check that your email address is verified (look for a confirmation email, check your spam folder just in case). If the issue persists, contact an administrator.

Known Gotchas and Installation Notes

Email verification and password reset functionality have not been implemented yet. Currently falls back to an ethereal test account. Both currently require direct contact with an admin for remediation.

Concurrent dev ports. `npm run dev` starts the Next.js frontend on port 3000 and the Express backend on port 5001. If either port is already in use, the process will fail quietly or bind to the wrong port. Check for stale processes with `lsof -i :5001` before starting.

Vercel serverless cold starts. The Express app is wrapped as a single serverless function via `api/index.ts`. Under low traffic, cold starts can make the first API request after idle feel slow, this is expected behavior, not a bug.

Admin role must be set manually. There's no signup flow for admins, you register a normal user then update the role directly in MongoDB. Forgetting this step and wondering why `/admin` returns 403 is a potential issue

Potential Issues with External Resources

JWT expired in production. JWT_EXPIRE=30d means sessions last 30 days with no refresh mechanism. If this is changed for security reasons later, existing logged-in users will get logged out unexpectedly.

Vercel's 10-second function timeout. Vercel's free tier enforces a 10-second execution limit on serverless functions. Any slow MongoDB query or unoptimized aggregation can breach this silently, returning a 504 to the client. Add indexes on frequently queried fields early.

Nodemailer and strict SMTP providers. Some providers like Gmail require app-specific passwords or OAuth, plain username/password auth is often blocked. For production, something like Resend or SendGrid should be used for better deliverability and to avoid spam blacklists.